campaign trail. She readily agreed and almost instantly got miked up for her first media interview.

For the next twelve hours, the young woman was pure television box office. She was wonderfully effervescent and spontaneous as she handled party workers and excited crowds with ease. She was able to strike an instant rapport with women in particular. Many of them would say, *'Beti, aap toh bilkul Indiraji kee tarah dikhti hai!'* (You look a lot like Indira Gandhi.)

I must confess I was bowled over. We even had lunch in the middle of a field in Amethi with Shinde lovingly serving us parathas and achar, all of it captured on camera. A few years later when Shinde became Maharashtra chief minister, I teased him that it was his lunch service in Amethi that did the trick!

I asked Priyanka whether she would enter politics. 'No, no. I am only here to help my mother. Otherwise, I am happy being away from it all,' she said with a smile. It's a refrain I would hear almost constantly for the next fifteen years. In 2004, when I returned to Amethi, she was there again, only this time she was helping her brother and mother who had now shifted to the neighbouring Rae Bareli constituency.

I kept in touch with Priyanka. She had kindly given me her mobile number, would always reply to an SMS and was helpful in fixing the odd meeting with Sonia. Occasionally, we'd bump into each other at a private gathering where she would be unfailingly gracious. The one time the equation seemed to sour was in 2012 when Kejriwal first raised the issue of her husband Robert Vadra's land deals. I asked if she or Robert would like to respond.

Her response was terse. 'Why don't you journalists leave us alone?

Do you know what impact all of this is having on my children?' I had read stories of how Priyanka was a devoted mother who often attended her children's sports events in school. She also strongly denied the Delhi gossip that she and Robert had separated. 'Where do you guys get all these stories from?' She sounded genuinely hurt and angry. I backed off a bit.